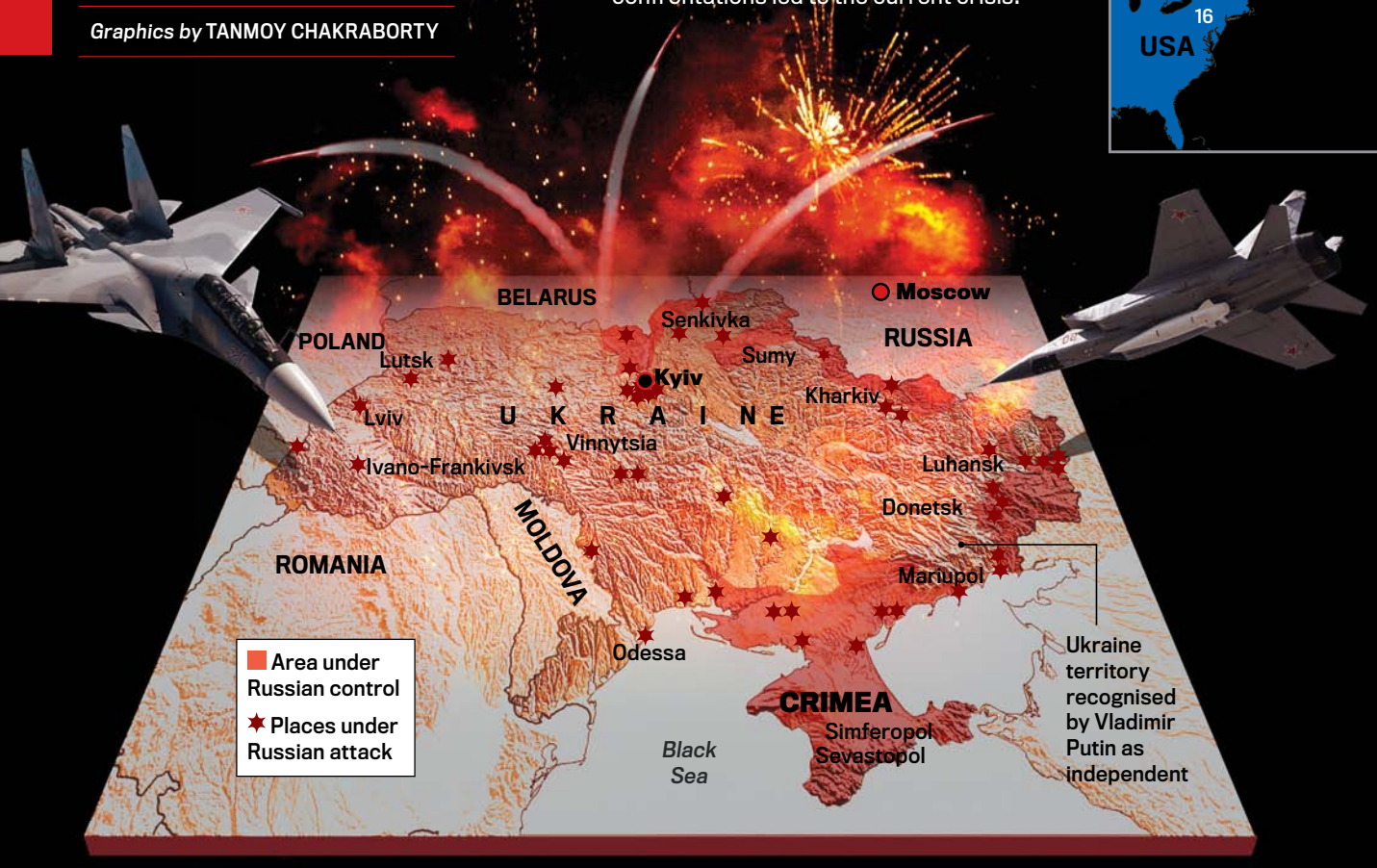
RUSSIA AND UKRAINE

A TORTURED HISTORY

Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

The second-largest country in Europe after Russia, Ukraine was born in 1991 after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. The separation created several points of friction between Russia and Ukraine, from the status of disputed Crimea to the ownership of the erstwhile Soviet Union's Black Sea fleet and its nuclear weapons emplaced in Ukraine. A look at how the festering confrontations led to the current crisis.





AUG. 1991

As the Soviet Union dissolves, Ukraine's parliament declares independence; a public referendum ratifies it. Unresolved issues between Ukraine and Russia include the USSR's military assets, including nukes and ships in the Black Sea.

MAY 1997

The two countries formalise division of Black Sea fleet. Russia acquires the majority in exchange for payment/ financial considerations

NOV. 2004

The pro-Kremlin Viktor Yanukovych wins the 2004 presidential polls against the pro-West **Viktor Yushchenko**. Alleging rigging, Yushchenko's supporters stage mass protests. The 'Orange Revolution' heralds a westward shift in Ukraine's politics. Yushchenko wins in fresh polls to become president.



FEB. 2005

Ukraine seeks NATO membership, gets US support. Talks begin.

APR. 2008

Putin says NATO's eastward expansion is a direct threat to Russia

AUG. 2008

Georgian president **Mikheil Saakashvili** pushes for Georgia to join NATO. Russia takes control of breakaway



Georgian regions South Ossetia and Abkhazia, declares them independent.

FEB. 2010

Yanukovych wins presidential polls, pushing Ukraine back into Kremlin's orbit

NOV. 2013

Euromaidan protests break out in Kyiv after Yanukovych refuses to sign 'association agreement' with EU that was to set the stage for removal of trade/ travel barriers

MAR. 2014

Russia formally annexes Crimea, including Sevastopol naval base

JUNE 2014

Ukraine's parliament votes to remove **Yanukovych**, who had fled the country in February. Presidential elections are held and Petro Poroshenko, a pro-West billionaire businessman, is elected. Tensions